



BEAUNE FRANCE

Tender Beef in Wine Country

Almost every French province has its own version of a beef stew, but vine-rich Burgundy's boeuf bourguignon has to be the most famous, and nowhere is it better made than in its birthplace. Perched in the center of the Côte d'Or wine region, the pretty town of Beaune is the perfect base for exploring the vineyards and cuisine of this exceptional part of France.



Burgundy has more than its share of legendary, grape-related names: Pommard, Romanée-Conti, Nuits-Saint-George, Montrachet. The red wines of this region are made from Pinot Noir grapes, the whites from Chardonnay. The greatest Burgundies hail from the celebrated Côte d'Or, which is divided into the Côte de Nuits and the Côte de Beaune – and the latter begins just north of the town of Beaune. Each village in the Burgundy region is like a small realm in the empire of wine, and majestic Beaune is its proud capital.

Historic buildings with multicolored tiled roofs line the cobbled streets of Beaune. Two of the most outstanding are the Hôtel des Ducs, now a wine museum, and the Hôtel Dieu des Hospices de Beaune, a masterpiece of medieval architecture built in 1443 as a hospital for the poor, dubbed the “Palace of the Poor” because of its Gothic grandeur. Now a museum, each November it throws open its doors for a charity wine auction, at which wines from vineyards gifted to the Hospice go under the hammer. The auction dates back to 1859 and a portion of the money raised still goes toward helping the sick, these days via the modern Beaune Hospital.

Beaune's streets are filled with palate-tempting restaurants and shops selling homemade jams, chocolates, cakes, aniseed candy, and fruit liqueurs. The twice-weekly market in the center of the old town is always a hive of activity, and the place to gather ingredients for a picnic lunch among the vines: *cabrion* (a goat cheese ripened in grape husks), farm-fresh terrines and pâtés, or a just-roasted Bresse chicken with crispy baby potatoes.

Local cooking is, unsurprisingly, awash with wine. “A la Bourguignon” denotes a dish made with plenty of wine, little white onions, a few mushrooms, and bacon – such as boeuf bourguignon, or *oeufs à la bourguignonne* (eggs poached in red wine). Burgundy's boeuf bourguignon isn't just a pot of stewed beef; this perennial wintry favorite must be made with Charolais beef, France's most tender and the region's best, doused in nothing else but a Burgundy red. The meat is braised with the wine, stock, onions, bacon, and mushrooms, so that as the sauce reduces, the flavor intensifies. In days gone by, before it morphed into a highbrow classic, boeuf bourguignon was simple farmers' food, and the long, slow cooking process evolved to tenderize tough cuts of meat. Even today, this is not a dish in a hurry.

A Day in Beaune

Beaune, an important cultural center in the Middle Ages, is a medieval city rich in history and tradition as well as a great place for food, wine-tasting, and shopping.

MORNING Soak up the past at **Hôtel Dieu des Hospices de Beaune**, pausing at red-curtained cubicles lining the “Room of the Poor” where the sick once languished, before stepping into the courtyard to see the dazzling glazed tile roof. Visit the 12th-century **Basilique Collégiale Notre Dame** for a glimpse of Gothic Beaune.

AFTERNOON Explore food and wine shops in **rue Carnot** and **rue Monge**. Join a mustard-tasting tour at **La Moutarderie Fallot**, a family mustard mill in operation since 1840, or visit a wine cellar in town, such as **Bouchard Père & Fils**. This has one of the greatest collections of Burgundy vintages and is housed in the glorious 15th-century **Château de Beaune**; the underground cellars have 23-ft- (7-m-) thick walls.

EVENING Stroll the **old town** to see the antique tiles and facades of buildings lit up against the night sky. Cozy up on a terrace with a velvety Burgundy.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Aéroport Dijon Bourgogne is 18 miles (30 km) from Beaune. **High-speed trains** operate from Paris, Lyon, and Dijon.

WHERE TO STAY

Les Jardins de Lois (inexpensive) is a serene and smart B&B. www.jardinsdelois.com
Via Mokis (moderate) is a modern hotel in the heart of the old town. www.viamokis.com
Hôtel de la Poste (expensive) is Beaune's oldest hotel; its stylish rooms feature French fabrics. www.hoteldelapostebeaune.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

1 rue de l'Hôtel-Dieu; www.ot-beaune.fr

